

up as negligible symptoms, but snowball into more serious health complications.

Occupational hazards

Nirav Shah is a standard 10 student who was exposed to computers as early in life as post-primary school. His parents, like most others, wanted their child to get a headstart in life. Today, they are quite perturbed by his hyperopic eyesight, amply evident by the growing thickness of his spectacles. Nirav spends most his time glued to the PC and shows all the symp-

is a disorder pertaining to the neck—inflammation of the vertebrae manifests as pain and stiffness. This, according to Dr Prakash Nelapana, a homeopath based in Mumbai, is the most common ailment among computer users. The usual culprit is the monitor, especially when placed at an improper level. Another common ailment is positional backache, which Dr Nelapana terms as Lumber Strain and believes it to be caused by improper chairs found in most offices (see box, 'The Workaholics Guide to Healthy Computing').

Other persistent health hazards are Carpel Tunnel Syndrome (CTS) and Repetitive Strain/Stress Injury (RSI). PC users most commonly complain of numbness or pain, anywhere from the shoulders to the joints of the fingers, weakness at the wrist, clumsiness while handling or holding things and nocturnal awakening. These are the symptoms of CTS—the inflammation of the tendons of the hand, brought about by repetitive activities involving the hand or wrist such as using the keyboard and the mouse over a prolonged period of time. Studies have shown that CTS comprises 13 per cent of all workplace injuries.

RSI is a more chronic ailment caused by overstrain that can develop unnoticed



Dr Prakash Nelapana
PRACTISING HOMEOPATH

Extreme cases of RSI can lead to permanent tissue damage and disability

toms of eyestrain caused by overexposure to the electromagnetic radiations emitted by the monitor—irritation in the eyes, strain, blurred vision, redness and burning.

The eyes are the first to get affected by prolonged computing and the spinal cord comes a close second. Cervical Spondylitis



The Workaholic's Guide to Healthy Computing

The Do's and Don'ts of long term computing sessions

- The shoulders should be relaxed; allow your elbows to swing free.
- Keep your wrists straight and parallel to the table.
- Pull your chin in to look down upon the monitor; do not propel your head forward. The distance between the monitor and your eyes should be around 60 cm. Don't slouch or slump forward; instead try leaning back in the chair.
- Alter your posture from time to time. Make sure that the small of your back is supported at all times.
- Take regular breaks every two hours—stretch your arms, neck and shoulders, and walk around. Flex your fingers by contracting and then stretching them out rapidly.
- Maintain a healthy diet and drink plenty of water.
- Look away from the monitor to a blank space after every 45 minutes and blink your eyes at regular intervals to avoid dryness.

Ergonomic Devices

The chair, mouse and the keyboard are the primary area where ergonomics should be applied in a work environment. Anti-glare screens meant to be placed on the monitor screen reduce the glare inherent in CRT displays that strain the eyes.

Monitors should be placed to offer a straight line of sight. While the most common arrangement is on top of the table, submerged monitors that are placed within the table, such as in the case of newsreaders and bank officials, need the user to look

down upon the screen, thus relaxing the neck muscles. Keyboards and mice are the source of RSI and CTS, hence it is important that you choose one that minimises the stress on your wrists and



A submerged monitor is the ideal way to place the device

shoulders. Most keyboards today, such as the ones from Logitech and Microsoft, come with palm rests that support your wrists. The buttons should be soft to touch and not require too much pressure. The customisable buttons, if any, should be placed within reach of the fingers. Curved keyboards, termed as Natural Keyboards, are ideal since they adapt to the natural positioning of the palms. Other ergonomic options are split keyboards, such as the Comfort Keyboard, which can be separated into two or more parts, but they are not



The Comfort Keyboard splits into three levels that can be customised for the user's comfort

easily available. These are adjustable in height, can be rotated and tilted up to 90 degrees for maximum comfort. Small keyboards made

for laptops should be avoided.

The mouse can also be an area of weakness because of the strain it puts on the wrist and the finger joints. The mouse should be large enough to fit snugly into the palm and raised enough from the centre so that the wrist is parallel to the surface area on which the mouse is placed—it should not require the wrist to be rested on the table. The buttons should not be too tacky and soft to press; a scroll wheel is advisable. Ideally, the mouse should be customisable for both left and right hand users and hence it should be symmetrical. The extra customisable buttons should be placed neither too near, nor too far and many come with a palm rest.



The Logitech MX 700 cordless optical mouse is a healthy gaming option